

SUMMIT TUITION ASSESSMENT

POEM COMPREHENSION PRACTICE PAPER*GL-style / QE-style — Difficult Inference Questions***Instructions to candidates**

- Read each poem carefully, twice, before answering its questions.
- Answer every question in full sentences using evidence from the poem.
- Use the P.E.E.L. method (Point, Evidence, Explain, Link) from your notes for every answer.
- Marks are shown in square brackets after each question.

Candidate name _____

Date _____

Time started / finished _____

POEM 1: THE OLD BOATHOUSE

The boathouse leans, half-swallowed by the reeds,
its timber ribs still counting out the tide.
No oar has stirred these waters in an age —
the lake keeps every secret it can hide.

My grandfather once rowed here, straight and sure,
his hands like rope, his voice a low, warm drum.
Now only rust remembers where he stood,
and I stand where his silence has become.

I press my palm against the greying wood
and feel, beneath the damp, a stubborn heat —
as though the boathouse holds one final breath
it will not, cannot, let itself complete.

I do not cry. I did not know him long.
But something in the hinge's rusted moan
insists that grief can live in borrowed rooms,
in objects we've inherited, not grown.

1. **WORD CHOICE** What does the word "counting" suggest about the boathouse's relationship with time in the first stanza? [3]

2. **TONE** How does the poet's tone shift between the second stanza and the final stanza? Use evidence from both. [3]

3. **STRUCTURE** Why might the poet have chosen to end the poem with the phrase "not grown" rather than ending on the image of the grandfather? [3]

4. **SPEAKER'S FEELINGS** The speaker says "I do not cry. I did not know him long." What does this reveal about how [3]
the speaker feels about their own grief?

5. **THEME** What is this poem suggesting about the way we inherit emotions or memories from people we barely [3]
knew?

POEM 2: STORM WARNING

The sky has turned the colour of a bruise.
Gulls scatter inland, screaming as they flee.
Mother pulls the shutters tight and says,
"It's only weather. Nothing else. You'll see."

But I have watched her knuckles, white and small,
gripping the latch as though it might give way.
I've counted seven storms in seven years —
none made her hands forget how to obey.

The wind arrives. It does not knock. It takes
the washing line, the fence, the garden chair.
It hurls itself against the trembling glass
like something furious, and unaware.

And when it's done — when morning shows its face,
pale and apologetic, softly lit —
we step outside to see what we have lost,
and Mother laughs, too quickly, over it.

1. **WORD CHOICE** Explain the effect of the word "bruise" in the first line. Why is this an unusual and effective word choice? [3]

2. **STRUCTURE** Why does the poet use short, blunt sentences in the line "It does not knock. It takes"? [3]

3. **INFERENCE** What does the detail about Mother's "white and small" knuckles suggest that her words "It's only weather" do not? [3]

4. **CHARACTER** Why do you think Mother "laughs, too quickly" at the end of the poem? What does this suggest about her true feelings? [3]

5. **THEME** What overall point might this poem be making about how adults try to protect children from fear? [3]

POEM 3: THE CLOCKMENDER'S WINDOW

Behind the glass, a hundred faces wait,
each frozen at a different hour of loss —
ten past, half two, the stubborn twenty-five
that never learned to let its minute pass.

The clockmender bends low with steady hands,
a jeweller's eye pressed tight against the springs.
He does not mend for money anymore.
He mends because a mended clock still sings.

They say his wife once loved this very sound —
the tick that filled the silence of their house.
Since she's been gone, he's fixed twelve hundred clocks,
as if he still might wind her footsteps out.

Tonight, one clock strikes true. Then, one by one,
the others catch its rhythm, hour by hour,
until the shop is loud with borrowed time —
and something in his shoulders loses power.

1. **WORD CHOICE** What does the phrase "frozen at a different hour of loss" suggest about the clocks in the shop window? [3]

2. **SYMBOLISM** What might the stopped clocks symbolise in relation to the clockmender's own life? [3]

3. **STRUCTURE** Why is it significant that the poem ends with the clocks finally striking "true" together, rather than earlier in the poem? [3]

4. **INFERENCE** What does the final line, "something in his shoulders loses power," suggest is happening to the clockmender emotionally? [3]

5. **THEME** What does this poem suggest about how people cope with grief through routine or repeated actions? [3]

POEM 4: LEAVING NUMBER NINE

The boxes swallow rooms that used to hold
the shape of us — our voices, worn-in chairs.
The hallway echoes strangely, wide and bare,
as though it, too, is startled that it's spared.

I trace the pencil marks along the frame
where every August measured how I'd grown.
Someone will paint them over, I suppose —
a stranger's height where mine has always shown.

Dad says, "New house, new start," and tries to smile,
but folds the last box shut a beat too slow.
I've learned that grown-ups hide their leaving, too,
inside the boxes marked "don't need — let go."

The van pulls off. I do not turn to look.
Some rooms you carry better in your mind
than through a rear-view mirror, growing small —
number nine, unshrinking, left behind.

1. **WORD CHOICE** What effect does the word "swallow" create in the opening line, and what does it suggest about the speaker's feelings towards moving? [3]
2. **INFERENCE** What does the detail of Dad folding "the last box shut a beat too slow" reveal about his true feelings, despite what he says? [3]
3. **STRUCTURE** Why do you think the poet chose to end the poem with the paradox "unshrinking, left behind" rather than a simpler, calmer image? [3]
4. **SPEAKER'S FEELINGS** Why might the speaker choose not to "turn to look" as the van pulls away? What does this decision suggest about how they are coping? [3]
5. **THEME** What is this poem suggesting about the difference between how children and adults each cope with a big change like moving house? [3]

Tutor Answer Guide — Model Points (not a full mark scheme, use to guide marking)

Poem 1 — The Old Boathouse: Q1: "counting" personifies the boathouse as patiently, almost obsessively tracking time passing, suggesting endurance/waiting. Q2: shifts from warm nostalgic memory (S2: "warm drum") to quiet unresolved grief (S4: "borrowed rooms"). Q3: ending on "not grown" universalises the idea — grief isn't only for what we experienced ourselves, it can be inherited, making the theme bigger than just this grandfather. Q4: shows the speaker feels their grief is somehow unearned or confusing, since they didn't know him well, yet it's still real. Q5: objects/places can carry emotional weight independent of direct memory — we can grieve secondhand.

Poem 2 — Storm Warning: Q1: "bruise" suggests injury, tenderness, and a sense of the sky being wounded/threatening — colour + pain associations. Q2: short blunt sentences mimic the storm's sudden, violent, uncontrollable arrival — mirrors how fear feels intrusive. Q3: her body language contradicts her calm words — a classic show-not-tell of hidden fear. Q4: she is masking fear/relief with forced humour to protect the child. Q5: adults often minimise danger verbally while their behaviour reveals real anxiety, showing protection can be imperfect/transparent.

Poem 3 — The Clockmender's Window: Q1: suggests each clock represents a frozen, painful moment in time — stuck rather than moving forward, as if loss stops time. Q2: the clocks symbolise his inability to "move on" from his wife's death — literally and emotionally stopped. Q3: the ending shows resolution/release — repairing time finally "working" mirrors an emotional turning point. Q4: suggests a release of built-up tension/grief — relief or a quiet emotional breakthrough. Q5: repetitive, purposeful routines can be a way of processing grief without confronting it directly.

Poem 4 — Leaving Number Nine: Q1: "swallow" suggests loss, being consumed/erased, and a slightly threatening, irreversible feeling about leaving. Q2: his hesitation reveals suppressed sadness despite his forced positivity — a physical "tell". Q3: the paradox captures how memory keeps a place "full-sized" in the mind even as it becomes physically distant — emotional truth vs. literal truth. Q4: avoiding looking back is a coping mechanism — facing the loss might feel too painful, so the speaker chooses avoidance/control. Q5: children may cope by holding on internally/refusing to watch, while adults perform forced positivity outwardly — both are masking real feelings differently.